

UNIVERSITY OF GEORGIA
CONSENT FORM
AI Voices of America

Instructions: Please read this form carefully before deciding whether to participate. Your participation is entirely voluntary.

Researcher's Statement

You are being asked to take part in a research study. The information in this form will help you decide if you want to be in the study. Please ask the researcher below if there is anything unclear or if you need more information.

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- Why is this study being done? Artificial Intelligence (AI) assistants, like those on your phone or smart speaker, are computer systems that can do tasks like people. They record and analyze voices every day. Most people do not know how much information their voice can reveal. Research has found that AI can guess a person's age, income, beliefs, and political views just from the sound of their voice. AI voice technology (systems that understand spoken language) does not work equally well for all Americans. It may make more mistakes for some groups. This can happen because the information used to build these systems does not represent all Americans equally. This study will collect short voice recordings and a survey from about 3,000 U.S. adults from across the country. Your participation will help researchers learn more about AI voice technology.
- Taking part in this study is your choice. You can decide not to join, stop at any time before submitting your voice recording, or request deletion of your data afterward, with no penalty or loss of benefits.
- This study will take approximately 10–15 minutes of your time.
- In this research you will answer survey questions about your background (gender, race/ethnicity, age, education, income, where you live, personality, job, mood, and political leaning). You will also record your voice in 2 short tasks: (1) read a short passage out loud for about 30 seconds, and (2) answer a simple question out loud for about 30 seconds.
- Risks of being in the study are:
 - (1) your raw voice recording (the original audio that can be played and heard) is biometric information (data that could potentially be used to identify you)
 - (2) some survey questions touch on sensitive topics like political leaning and income level. You may skip the personality, interests, and mood questions if you do not want to answer them, but the other background questions, including political leaning, are required; and
 - (3) There is a small chance of someone getting your information without permission. We will take steps to reduce these risks.
- Your participation may help researchers better understand AI voice privacy risks and build fairer AI systems for all Americans in the future.

You are being asked to participate because you are 18 years of age or older and are currently residing in the United States.

If you are interested in participating in the study, please read the additional information below and feel free to ask questions at any point.

Study Procedures and Time Commitment

This study will take no more than 10–15 minutes and is a one-time participation. The steps are as follows: (1) Complete a short survey (5–7 minutes). (2) Read a short passage out loud for around 30 seconds. (3) Answer a simple question out loud for around 30 seconds. (4) Submit your voice recording. Save your study ID number, which is displayed on screen when you submit the recording. You will need it to request deletion of your data later. (5) Provide your name, birthday, email address, and mailing address for delivery of the payment.

Payment: You will receive a \$5.00 prepaid VISA card delivered by email. Your full name, email address, mailing address, and birthday are required for payment delivery. This information is stored completely separately from your survey answers and voice recordings and will never be linked to them. It is deleted after your payment is confirmed.

Risks and Discomforts

- **Privacy and identification risk:** Some questions ask about topics like your political views, income, race or ethnicity, mood, and personality. You may feel uncomfortable answering them. These questions are included to help make sure the study represents people from all backgrounds. The personality, interests, and current mood questions include a “Prefer not to answer” option, and you may select that option for any of those items if you prefer not to answer. The other background questions and the voice recording tasks are required to participate. These questions are required because the study needs a balanced sample of Americans and uses your answers to decide which groups still need more participants. Political leaning is required because it is one of the main things this study examines: whether AI voice systems work differently for people with different political views. If you are not comfortable answering it, you should not take part in the study. Your answers are stored only under a random study ID with no link to your identity.
Your voice is biometric information and could be used to identify you. We treat two forms of voice data differently to reduce this risk: (a) your raw voice (audio) recording, the original audio that can be played and heard, is the most identifiable form, and (b) the numbers that describe your voice but are not audio (called “embeddings”), which are much harder to link back to you.
- **Voice Recording Storage and Access:** Voice recordings are collected using a tool built by our research team that runs directly in your web browser. You do not need to install an app, plugin, or download anything, and no outside company receives or processes your recording. The recordings are protected by security measures while they are being sent and stored on secure online servers managed by the research team. The recording tool does not keep its own copies. Each audio file is labeled with a random study ID, not your name. Access to the recording is limited to approved research team members and we keep a record of who accesses the recordings.
- **Embeddings Storage and Access:** Embeddings will be stored on secured infrastructure and will only be accessed by individuals part of the AI Voices of America Project, and those authorized through access requests viewed by the project team.
- **Voice Recording Retention and Deletion:** Your raw voice recording will be kept for up to 10 years and then permanently deleted. We keep the raw recording so that, as voice AI technology improves, researchers can re-analyze the recordings with newer and more accurate methods. You may request

deletion of your raw recording and survey responses at any time during those 10 years by entering your study ID at https://terry.qualtrics.com/jfe/form/SV_eVsevfSXuGUD8mG.

- **Embeddings Retention and Deletion:** Embeddings are generated automatically from your raw recording at the time you submit it, and may be regenerated from the raw recording later using improved methods. Embeddings will be kept indefinitely. If you request deletion of your raw recording, the embeddings and survey responses derived from it will also be deleted from our repository and from any future data releases. If they have already been provided to an approved researcher, we cannot guarantee removal from that researcher's copy.
- **Voice Recording External Sharing:** Your voice recording will not be shared outside the research team.
- **Embeddings and survey responses** may be shared with other researchers with limited and controlled access permission. See the Sharing Plan below.
- **Risk of data breach:** As with any data stored online, there is a small chance someone could access it without permission. We protect your data using strong security. Even if our systems were compromised, your audio cannot be read without special keys (encryption) that only the research team has.

Benefits

There is no direct benefit to you for this research. Your participation may help others by helping researchers understand privacy risks, learn if voice systems are fair for different groups, and improve these systems for everyone.

Confidentiality of Records

Your survey answers are saved under a random study ID number, not your name. The study ID number is chosen by a computer and is not based on your name or other personal information. There is no list anywhere connecting your ID to your identity. Your name, email and mailing address are stored separately from your research data. Your raw audio recording will not be shared outside the research team. As described in the Dissemination and Sharing Plan, embeddings and your survey responses may be shared with other researchers under restricted access. Important: Because this study is conducted over the internet, we cannot guarantee complete confidentiality. There is a small risk that information shared online could be accessed or used by others outside the research team, as with any activity you do online. We have taken strong steps to reduce this risk, but it cannot be completely eliminated.

Dissemination and Sharing Plan

A goal of this study is to build a research dataset that helps the scientific community study AI voice technology, including how well AI voice systems work for different groups of Americans. The results of our research will be shared through academic journal articles, conference presentations, and reports posted on a public project website: <https://aivoicesofamerica.org>. The dataset of embeddings will be made available to other researchers under the following terms:

Who can access it: Access is restricted to qualified researchers and is granted on a case-by-case basis after review of each request by the research team. Approved researchers must agree to data use terms that prohibit attempts to re-identify participants and prohibit redistribution of the data.

How it will be hosted: The embeddings will be stored in a research-team-managed repository with access controlled by the research team. The project website will provide updates on publications, descriptions of the

dataset, and instructions on how qualified researchers can request access. Any future scholarly research use of the embeddings data beyond what is described here would require additional review and approval by a committee, an Institutional Review Board (IRB). IRBs follow government regulations to ensure that research is safe and ethical.

Participant Rights

If there are any questions you may direct them to Scott Schanke at scott.schanke@uga.edu. If you have any questions or concerns regarding your rights as a research participant in this study, you may contact the Institutional Review Board (IRB) Chairperson at 706.542.3199 or irb@uga.edu.

If you decide to stop being in the study, you may do so at any time before submitting your recording. Once you have submitted your recording, your survey answers and recording are stored under your study ID, which is displayed on screen after you submit. If you want to withdraw from the study after submitting, enter your study ID at https://terry.qualtrics.com/jfe/form/SV_eVsevfSXuGUD8mG at any time during the 10-year retention period, and your raw recording, survey answers, and embeddings will be removed as described above. If you do not know your study ID, the research team will be unable to locate and delete your data. A copy of this consent document is available for you to download or print for your records.